The youngster was Harlan Ellison, 2 you see, and I had never met him before and didn't know his utter irreverence. But everyone else there knew him and they had waited for innocent me to be neatly poniarded—and I had been. Someone might have warned me, but no one did.

It was all good clean fun, and ever since then Harlan and I have loved each other deeply and truly, but he can't ever come near me without my breaking out into a rash of small-jokes, and he is equally prone to fat-jokes.

The fan world tends to think there's a deadly feud between us, but they're quite wrong. It's just our way of honing our wise-guyishness against each other's sensibilities. 3

On the evening of the fifth, Sprague, John Clark, and I went out to a local radio station where a local talk-show host interviewed us. We were made to order for him, for he thought it the funniest thing in the world that science-fiction people were having a convention. ("What do you do, wear beanies?")

Sprague answered very patiently, for he is the soul of dignity and forbearance, but I chafed a bit. Finally, when it was my turn again, the host said to me, "Say, I have a question for you: Suppose you are on Pluto and you're wearing those funny space helmets. How do you kiss?"

"You don't," I said, glowering at him. "You carry on a Plutonic love affair."

The studio audience broke up and it was the host's turn to glower. Apparently guests are not supposed to take the play away from the host. He didn't speak to me again.

I was toastmaster at the banquet on September 6, and did well. It was my first stint as toastmaster, but not my last.

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I finished The Chemicals of Life on September 15, 1953. It had taken me only nine weeks despite the interruption of the convention and the confusion following the end of the agency.

I made an important discovery: It was easier and faster writing nonfiction than fiction. I had thought so when I wrote the textbook, but the long and tedious sessions with Walker and Boyd had obscured the discovery.

2 Harlan insists he said, "You aren't so much," but I think well of my memory